Precorrections

Preventing predictable problems before they start

Use a precorrection when a predictable situation repeatedly produces the same difficulty. Prompt the desired action immediately before that moment, using the pattern you have noticed.

How to do it well

1 Spot the pattern. Identify when, where, with whom and after what trigger the behaviour reliably occurs; act on a pattern, not an isolated bad day.

2 Name the replacement behaviour. Describe what pupils should do in positive, specific and observable language that is incompatible with the problem behaviour.

3 Adjust the setup. Change seating, resources, timing, task design or the physical environment so the expected response becomes easier.

4 Rehearse and prompt at the right time. Ask pupils to recall the routine shortly beforehand, then use a brief word, gesture or visual cue at the point of action.

5 Reinforce and check. Name successful enactment, monitor whether the pattern changes and reduce the prompt from a sentence to a gesture to nothing as fluency grows.

What this sounds like

“Before the trays move, carry yours with both hands and walk directly to your bench. We practised this route; use it now.”

Classroom example. A teacher notices that a familiar equipment transition repeatedly produces crowding. Just before it, the teacher reminds pupils of the taught collection route and adjusts the location of the resources. Successful execution is recognised. As the route becomes fluent, the spoken reminder is shortened and eventually removed.

Top tips that make the technique work

Be specific about the pattern. Identify when, where and what goes wrong so the reminder is targeted.

Name the action you want. “Carry the tray with both hands” gives more useful information than “Don’t mess about.”

Time the cue carefully. A reminder well before the risky moment may no longer be available when needed.

Adjust the setup too. Resource placement or task clarity can remove a recurring obstacle.

Fade the reminder. As the routine becomes fluent, reduce spoken prompts to a gesture or no prompt.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Prompt a taught action just before it is needed.	A threat presented as a reminder.
Reinforce the successful response.	Repeating a generic warning without identifying a pattern.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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